

THE CATALYZING EVENT

The Project for the New American Century, 9/11 & The Architecture of Pre-Planned War

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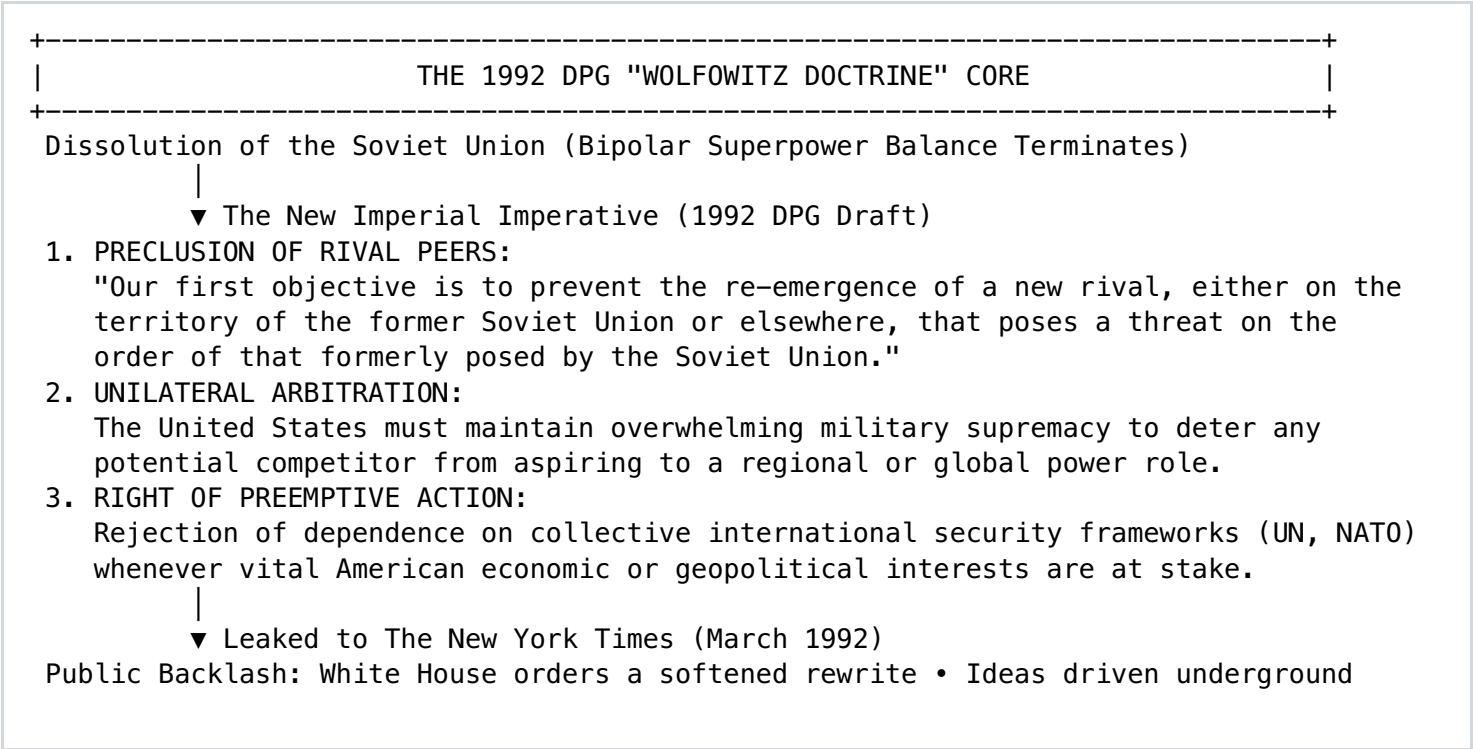
FORENSIC INVESTIGATIVE DIRECTIVE: The catastrophic attacks of September 11, 2001, were presented to the global public as an unforeseen historical rupture that fundamentally altered American foreign policy overnight. Declassified government archives, think-tank planning documents, and contemporaneous memoranda reveal a different reality: the post-9/11 national security doctrine—unilateral preemptive warfare, regime change in the Middle East, massive defense spending surges, and the permanent weaponization of space—was detailed in precise technical form throughout the 1990s by the **Project for the New American Century (PNAC)**. The core signatories of PNAC's founding charter—Dick Cheney, Donald Rumsfeld, Paul Wolfowitz, I. Lewis Libby, and John Bolton—transitioned from private political lobbying directly into the apex decision-making posts of the George W. Bush administration in January 2001. When the attacks occurred, this network did not improvise a response; they superimposed their pre-existing ideological roadmap onto the crisis. This volume presents a forensic audit of the documents, institutional revolving doors, and manufactured intelligence that transformed an unheeded warning into an era of perpetual war.

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1. THE INTELLECTUAL GENESIS: THE 1992 WOLFOWITZ DOCTRINE

The intellectual architecture of post-Cold War American unilateralism originated in the final months of the George H.W. Bush presidency. Following the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991, Under Secretary of Defense for Policy **Paul Wolfowitz** and his principal deputy **I. Lewis "Scooter" Libby**, directed by Secretary of Defense **Dick Cheney**, drafted a classified internal policy blueprint: the **1992 Defense Planning Guidance (DPG)**.



When the draft DPG was leaked to the press in March 1992, it generated public controversy. Criticized as an imperial manifesto for global dominance, the elder Bush administration ordered the document sanitized. However, its authors did not abandon the thesis; they retreated to conservative foundations and corporate boards to construct a formal political lobbying vehicle that would wait for the next Republican presidency.

2. THE FOUNDATION: KRISTOL, KAGAN & THE 1997 MANIFESTO

In the spring of 1997, **William Kristol** (editor of Rupert Murdoch's *The Weekly Standard*) and foreign policy analyst **Robert Kagan** formally established the **Project for the New American Century (PNAC)** at 1150 17th Street NW in Washington, D.C.—operating in the same building as the American Enterprise Institute (AEI).

On June 3, 1997, PNAC published its **Statement of Principles**, calling for a dramatic increase in defense spending, a foreign policy of "military strength and moral clarity," and the aggressive use of American military power to shape the global environment.

**Project for the New American Century:
Statement of Principles**

Washington, D.C. • June 3, 1997 •
Foundational Charter

"We need to accept responsibility for America's unique role in preserving and extending an international order friendly to our security, our prosperity, and our principles... Such a Reaganite policy of military strength and moral clarity may not be fashionable today. But it is necessary if the United States is to build upon the successes of this past century and to ensure our security and our greatness in the next."

Historical Record of Signatories: The charter was signed by twenty-five prominent neoconservative figures. Within four years, **ten of these signatories** would be appointed to lead the national security, foreign policy, and intelligence apparatus of the United States.

PNAC Founding Signatory (1997)	Subsequent Bush Administration Appointment (2001)	Operational Role in the Global War on Terror
Dick Cheney	Vice President of the United States	Executive director of covert foreign policy; chairman of the Special Situation Group.
Donald Rumsfeld	Secretary of Defense	Architect of the Afghan and Iraq invasions; authorized enhanced interrogation.
Paul Wolfowitz	Deputy Secretary of Defense	Direct supervisor of the Office of Special Plans; chief architect of the Iraq war plan.
I. Lewis "Scooter" Libby	Chief of Staff to the Vice President	Managed intelligence stovepiping; later convicted in the Valerie Plame CIA leak scandal.
John Bolton	Under Secretary of State for Arms Control	Dismantled the ABM Treaty; pressured international inspectors on chemical weapons.
Zalmay Khalilzad	NSC Senior Director • U.S. Ambassador	Directed post-invasion governance transitions in Kabul (2003) and Baghdad (2005).
Elliott Abrams	Senior Director, National Security Council	Pardoned Iran-Contra figure; managed Middle East democracy-promotion initiatives.

3. THE TARGET IDENTIFIED: THE 1998 LETTERS TO CLINTON

Long before the September 11 attacks, PNAC's institutional priority was the military overthrow of the Ba'athist government in Iraq. On January 26, 1998, PNAC sent an open letter to President **Bill Clinton**, explicitly urging him to abandon the diplomatic containment strategy and initiate unilateral military action to remove Saddam Hussein from power.

PNAC Open Letter to President William J. Clinton

January 26, 1998 • Declassified Foreign Policy Archive

*"We urge you to seize that opportunity, and to enunciate a new strategy that would secure the interests of the U.S. and our allies... That strategy should aim, above all, at **the removal of Saddam Hussein's regime from power.**"*

"We believe the U.S. has the authority under existing UN resolutions to take the necessary steps, including military steps, to protect our vital interests in the Gulf. In any case, American policy cannot continue to be crippled by a misguided insistence on unanimity in the UN Security Council."

Signatures Include: Donald Rumsfeld, Paul Wolfowitz, Richard Perle, John Bolton, Richard Armitage, Robert Zoellick, and Zalmay Khalilzad.

When the Clinton administration declined to launch an immediate full-scale ground invasion, PNAC followed up on May 29, 1998, with an open letter to Speaker of the House **Newt Gingrich** and Senate Majority Leader **Trent Lott**. This pressure campaign led directly to the passage of the **Iraq Liberation Act of 1998** (Public Law 105-338), which codified regime change in Iraq as official United States statutory policy, funded Ahmad Chalabi's Iraqi National Congress (INC), and laid the legal foundation for the 2003 invasion.

4. "REBUILDING AMERICA'S DEFENSES": THE NEW PEARL HARBOR

In September 2000, two months prior to the presidential election, PNAC published its master architectural study: **"Rebuilding America's Defenses: Strategy, Forces and Resources For a New Century" (RAD)**. Chaired by Donald Kagan and Gary Schmitt and authored by Thomas Donnelly, the 90-page document outlined the exact operational layout later implemented by the Bush administration.

PNAC'S "REBUILDING AMERICA'S DEFENSES" (2000)

FOUR CORE OPERATIONAL MISSIONS:

1. Defend the American Homeland (Deploy National Missile Defense / Cancel ABM Treaty)
2. Fight and Decisively Win Multiple, Simultaneous Major Theater Wars (MTWs)
3. Perform Constabulary Duties (Maintain permanent forward-deployed bases worldwide)
4. Transform U.S. Forces (Exploit the "Revolution in Military Affairs" / Space Dominance)

▼ REGIONAL GEOPOLITICAL IMPERATIVE (Page 14)

"The United States has for decades sought to play a more permanent role in Gulf regional security. While the unresolved conflict with Iraq provides the immediate justification, the need for a substantial American force presence in the Gulf transcends the issue of the regime of Saddam Hussein."

▼ THE SYSTEMIC BOTTLENECK: POLITICAL WILL (Page 51)

"Further, the process of transformation, even if it brings revolutionary change, is likely to be a long one, absent some catastrophic and catalyzing event – LIKE A NEW PEARL HARBOR."

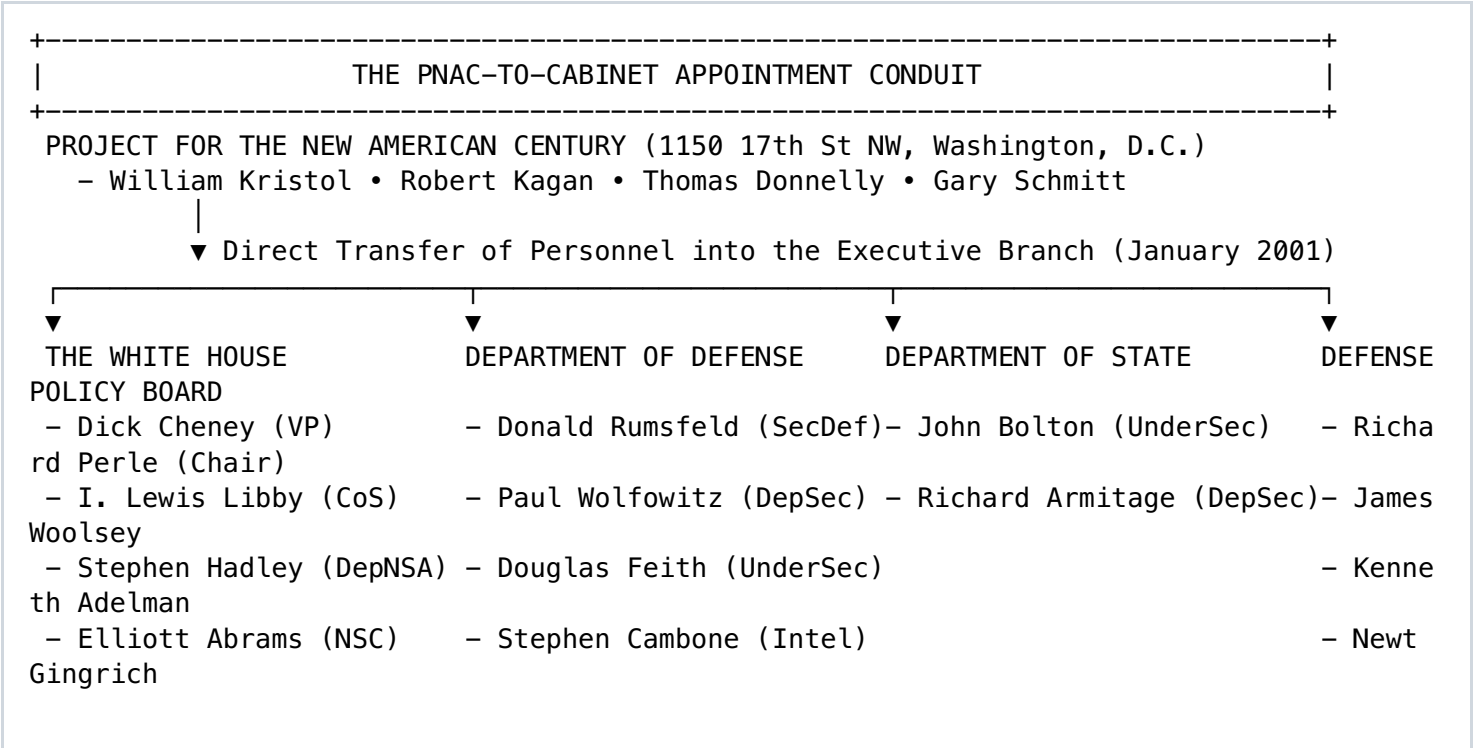
The Strategic Meaning of the "New Pearl Harbor"

The passage in Section V of *Rebuilding America's Defenses* is frequently misunderstood as a literal conspiracy admission. In historical and strategic context, it reveals an analytical calculation: the authors understood that democratic populations during peacetime will not support massive military budget increases, overseas imperial garrisoning, and domestic surveillance expansion without a unifying national security shock.

A "catastrophic and catalyzing event" was viewed by PNAC not as a scenario to be avoided, but as an operational prerequisite to overcome congressional resistance and historical inertia.

5. THE EXECUTIVE INFILTRATION: THE 2001 CABINET APPOINTMENTS

Following the contested resolution of the 2000 election in Florida, George W. Bush took office in January 2001. Rather than drawing national security personnel from mainstream academic or diplomatic pools, the incoming administration staffed its foreign policy leadership almost entirely from the roster of PNAC signatories and fellows.



The Pre-9/11 Focus on Iraq

Former Treasury Secretary **Paul O'Neill** revealed in 2004 that from the earliest National Security Council meetings in January and February 2001—eight months prior to September 11—the primary topic of discussion was the military overthrow of Saddam Hussein and the post-war division of Iraq’s oil reserves:

"From the very beginning, there was a conviction that Saddam Hussein was a bad person and that he needed to go... For me, the question was: 'Where is the evidence?' It was all about finding a way to do it. That was the tone of it. The president saying, 'Go find me a way to do this.'"

- Paul O'Neill, 72nd U.S. Secretary of the Treasury (2001–2002)

6. THE SUMMER OF INACTION: DISMISSING AL-QAEDA (2001)

Throughout the spring and summer of 2001, professional counter-terrorism intelligence analysts—led by National Security Council National Coordinator for Counterterrorism **Richard A. Clarke** and CIA Director **George Tenet**—delivered urgent warnings to the new administration regarding an imminent, large-scale domestic al-Qaeda attack.

These warnings were dismissed or deprioritized by the neoconservative leadership at the Pentagon and White House, whose strategic priorities remained focused on state-centric threats, National Missile Defense (NMD), and planning the overthrow of Iraq.

Date	Documented Intelligence Warning	Executive Action Taken by Administration
January 25, 2001	Richard Clarke submits urgent strategy memo to Condoleezza Rice requesting emergency cabinet meeting on al-Qaeda cells.	Cabinet-level Principals meeting delayed for eight months; finally convened on September 4, 2001.
May–July 2001	CIA intelligence systems report over 30 separate warnings of an imminent, catastrophic attack; "system blinking red."	Deputy Defense Secretary Paul Wolfowitz dismisses Osama bin Laden as a distraction, arguing Iraq is the real sponsor.
August 6, 2001	President's Daily Brief (PDB): <i>"Bin Ladin Determined To Strike in US."</i> Explicitly warns of hijacked airliners.	President Bush remains on a month-long vacation in Crawford, Texas; zero inter-agency alerts issued to FAA or domestic airports.

The Strategic Blindspot

The refusal to act on asymmetric terrorist warnings was an institutional blindspot. The PNAC paradigm did not account for non-state actors operating with commercial utility knives; it was built to wage state-on-state wars against mid-level powers in the Middle East and prepare for future conflict with China. The administration's focus left the domestic homeland open to attack.

7. SEPTEMBER 11 AS THE ENABLER: "SWEEP IT ALL UP"

On the morning of September 11, 2001, nineteen hijackers weaponized four civilian jetliners, destroying the World Trade Center towers in New York and striking the Pentagon in Arlington, Virginia.

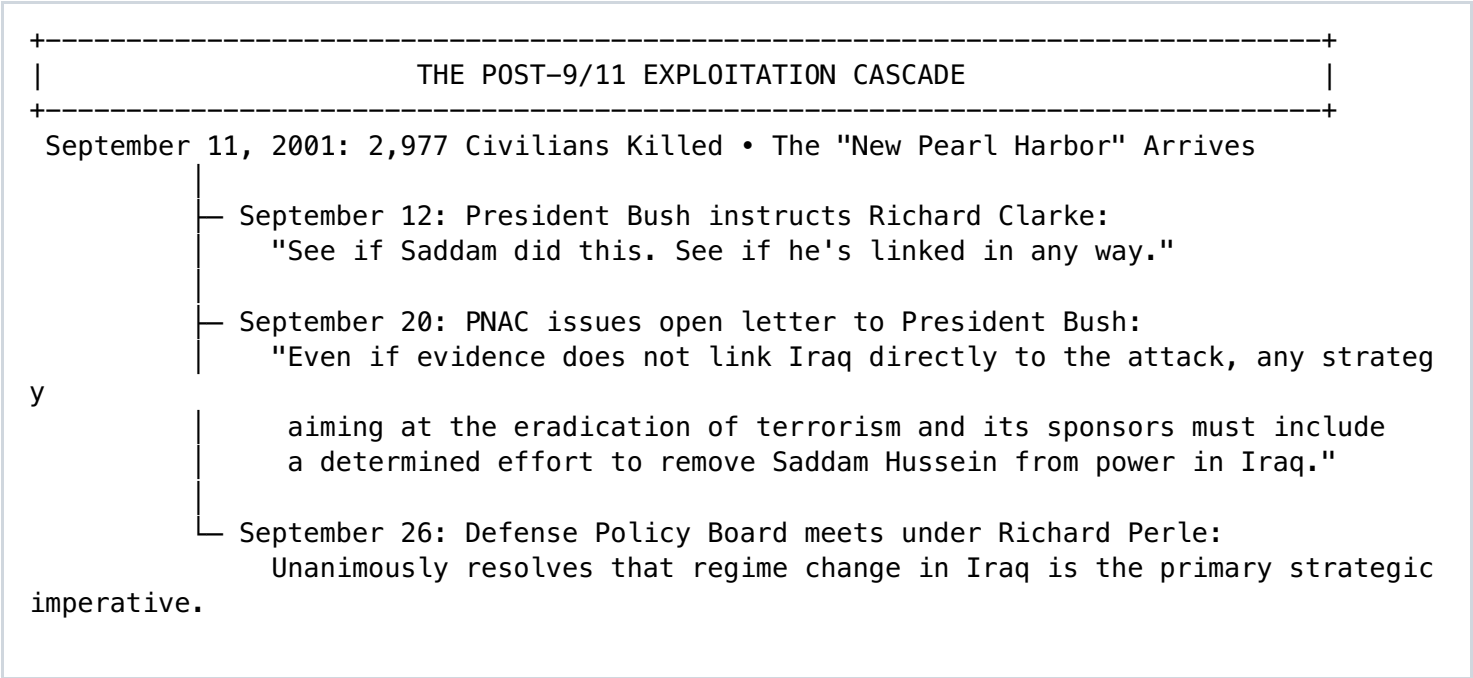
Within hours of the catastrophic attacks, while smoke was still rising from the Pentagon, Secretary of Defense Donald Rumsfeld and his deputies moved to expand the military response beyond the perpetrators of 9/11 to target Iraq.

National Archives: Handwritten Notes of Stephen Cambone

Transcribing Secretary Donald Rumsfeld • Pentagon • 2:40 PM, September 11, 2001

"Best info fast. Judge whether good enough hit S.H. [Saddam Hussein] at same time. Not only UBL [Usama bin Laden]... Need to move swiftly..."

"Near term target needs—Go massive. Sweep it all up. Things related and not."



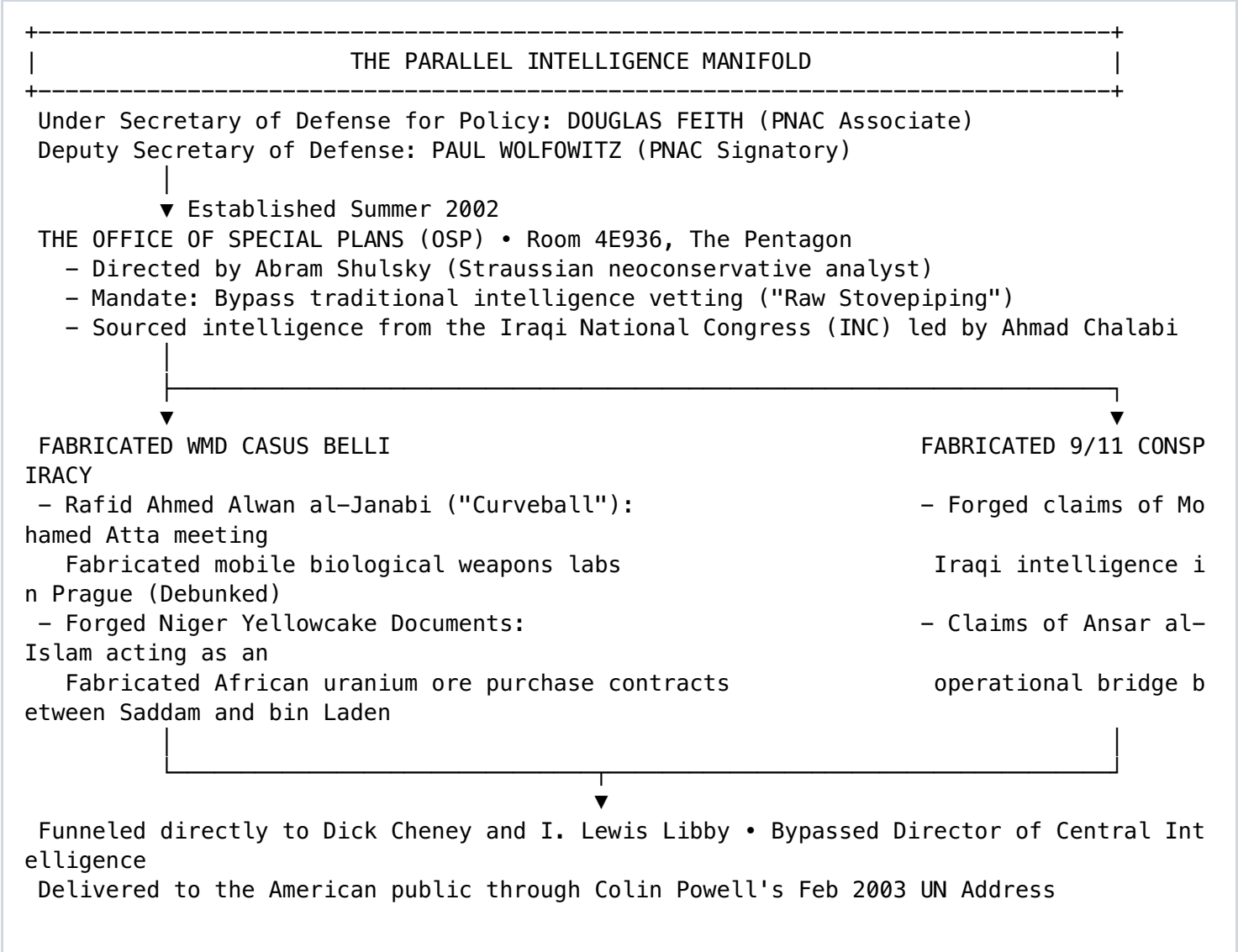
The Instrumentalization of Grief

PNAC's pre-existing policy goals were mapped onto the nation's grief and anger. The complex problem of transnational Islamic extremism was reframed as a state-sponsorship problem solvable through conventional military invasions, shifting the focus from Afghanistan toward Iraq.

8. THE INTELLIGENCE FABRICATION MACHINE: SPECIAL PLANS

Because professional intelligence agencies (the CIA's Directorate of Intelligence and the State

Department's Bureau of Intelligence and Research [INR]) repeatedly concluded that Saddam Hussein was ideologically hostile to al-Qaeda and that Iraq possessed no operational links to 9/11, the PNAC network inside the Pentagon created a dedicated bureaucratic cell to manufacture alternative findings.



The Senate Intelligence Committee Assessment

The 2007 report by the Senate Select Committee on Intelligence formally concluded that Douglas Feith's Office of Special Plans engaged in *"inappropriate, non-validated, and unauthorized activities"* by producing and disseminating alternative intelligence assessments that contradicted the consensus of the intelligence community to justify war.

9. THE BUSH DOCTRINE: CODIFYING PNAC POLICY

In September 2002, the White House published the **National Security Strategy of the United States of America (NSS 2002)**. The document represented the formal adoption of PNAC’s 1997 Statement of Principles and the 2000 *Rebuilding America's Defenses* as official, binding United States foreign policy.

The National Security Strategy of the United States of America

Executive Office of the President • September 2002 • The "Bush Doctrine"

*"The United States has long maintained the option of preemptive actions to counter a sufficient threat to our national security... The greater the threat, the greater is the risk of inaction—and the more compelling the case for taking anticipatory action to defend ourselves, **even if uncertainty remains as to the time and place of the enemy's attack.**"*

Structural Alignment: The document officially codified the right to wage preventive war—a concept barred by the United Nations Charter (Article 2, Section 4)—transforming the United States military from a defensive deterrent force into a global expeditionary instrument.

PNAC Policy Goal (1997–2000)	NSS 2002 Formal Adoption	Operational Geopolitical Result
Regime change in Iraq	Targeting hostile regimes seeking WMDs	Invasion of Iraq (March 2003); capture and execution of Saddam Hussein.
Permanent Gulf basing infrastructure	Deepening forward military access	Permanent mega-bases in Qatar, Bahrain, Kuwait, and Iraq.
Dismantling of the ABM Treaty	Unilateral strategic modernization	U.S. withdrawal from ABM Treaty (June 2002); Space Force pre-cursor programs.
Preemptive military doctrine	Anticipatory self-defense	Drone strike warfare across Pakistan, Yemen, Somalia, and Libya.

10. FORENSIC AUDIT LEDGER: DECONSTRUCTING PRETEXTS

For independent intelligence researchers, legal scholars, and forensic historians investigating manufactured pretexts for conflict, the convergence of PNAC and 9/11 establishes the operational template for identifying policy-driven wars:

- [] **Audit Policy Manifestos Pre-Dating Conflicts:** Identify whether military objectives executed following a national crisis were detailed in think-tank white papers published years prior to the event.
- [] **Trace the Personnel Revolving Door:** Cross-reference the signatories of non-governmental interventionist petitions with incoming cabinet, defense, and national security council appointments.
- [] **Analyze Intelligence Stovepiping Units:** Scrutinize ad-hoc intelligence evaluation cells (e.g., Office of Special Plans) set up outside professional analytical channels to deliver pre-determined findings.
- [] **Examine Casus Belli Disconnects:** Compare the formal pretext delivered to the public (e.g., direct retaliation for an attack) against internal government tasking orders targeting unrelated nations.
- [] **Track Post-Invasion Resource Realization:** Map whether military interventions secure long-term military basing access and energy extraction concessions outlined in pre-war planning documents.
- [] **Investigate Non-Competitive Contractor Beneficiaries:** Audit multi-billion-dollar defense, reconstruction, and logistics contracts awarded to corporate entities tied to executive administration officials.
- [] **Document Long-Term Strategic Costs:** Account for the total human, financial, and geopolitical fallout—including the death of over 500,000 civilians, the regional emergence of extremist factions, and multi-trillion-dollar fiscal debts—resulting from the execution of pre-planned ideological wars.